BUSN 7980: The Modern Leader

Orchestrating outcomes through influence, impact, and career mastery

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General Course Information

Students will gain the tools and strategies to build a productive, fruitful and fulfilling career while navigating a dynamic job market. Students will learn to position themselves as a marketable offering, identify and secure career opportunities, and expand their influence and career trajectory. It will teach frameworks that are applied to leading change and leading teams. The course blends classroom engagement, , group work, role plays, and applied assignments to build confidence and capability in real-world situations.

Why Orchestrating Outcomes Matters

In the age of AI, leadership and career mastery are increasingly defined by a person's ability to deliver business outcomes by guiding decisions, leading & aligning cross-functional teams, and moving work forward - with and without formal authority.

This course teaches students how to influence outcomes through clear communication, disciplined thinking, leading change and orchestrating execution. Students will learn how to convert ideas into cross-functional action, create clarity in complex environments, and lead teams through change. The course uses practical frameworks, live feedback, classroom dialogue, guest speakers, leadership exercises, and applied projects to help students develop the confidence and capability required to make an immediate material contribution in any organization.

Students will also build the skills needed to shape their careers with intention. The course covers how to position yourself for meaningful opportunities, communicate your value in a direct and compelling way, and expand the relationships that create long-term momentum. You will practice interviewing, outreach, negotiation, storytelling, and presentation skills, while also learning how organizations evaluate talent, potential, and leadership qualities. By the end of the course, students will understand how to identify the right roles, pursue them effectively, and step into them ready to create real impact.

Learning Outcomes

- Articulate a compelling leadership brand that aligns personal and professional goals.
- Identify and assess strong career fits.
- Craft and deliver a professional pitch that communicates value to targeted audiences.

- Proactively create opportunities through cold outreach and informational interviews.
- Excel in interviews by applying behavioral, case, and situational frameworks, asking high-impact questions, and negotiating effectively.
- Communicate business recommendations through concise, persuasive presentations, memos, and value-based storytelling.
- Understand how to break down a significant leadership assignment into units of work and create an operating rhythm to deliver needed outcomes.
- Demonstrate leadership and executive presence by aligning on vision, owning execution plans, and leading through influence.
- Apply frameworks for execution, leading change, and delivering feedback.
- Understand sales and revenue in B2B environments.

"Writing is a tool for thinking, most importantly, and I don't think that's going anywhere. It's really important that people still learn to write for this reason.
- Sam Altman, OpenAI Founder and CEO

Topical Outline (Week by Week)

- *Module details are subject to change and may evolve with our interactions.*
- *An assignment is not an assignment until discussed in class.*

1. 1/12: You, Inc. and Career Mastery: Self Awareness as a Foundation for Career Mastery
    a. Frameworks: Ikagi, Career Thinking, Eurich's Internal and External Self Awareness
    b. Assignment: You Inc
2. 1/26: You, Inc. and Career Mastery: Charting Your Course | Pitching Your Story
    a. Frameworks and Tools: Career Ladders and Lattices, STAR, PSR,
    b. Assignment: Chart Your Course | Pitch Your Story
3. 2/2: You, Inc. and Career Mastery: Opening Doors, Outreach & Informational Interviewing
    a. Framework and Tools: SMYKM, Apollo.io, Informational Interviewing
    b. Assignment: SMYKM Prep (30 minute video series)
    c. Assignment: Outreach to 10 aspirational individuals who can help you on your path
4. 2/9: You, Inc. and Career Mastery: Effective Interviewing and Interviewer Empathy
    a. Framework and Tools: Networking and Informational Interviewing
    b. Assignment: Begin Reading How to Win Friends and Influence People, Dale Carnegie
5. 2/16: Clear Business Writing and Thinking: MINTO
    a. Framework and Tools: MINTO – Pyramid Principle
    b. Assignment: MINTO Writeup
    c. Assignment: 4DX Prep:
6. 2/23: Orchestrating Outcomes: Influence With, and Without Formal Authority
    a. Framework and Tools: Carnegie: Win Friends and Influence People
    b. Assignment: MINTO Preparation
7. 3/2: Orchestrating Outcomes: Management & Execution Discipline
    a. Framework and Tools: Four Disciplines of Execution (4DX)
8. 3/16: Orchestrating Outcomes: Management & Execution Discipline 2
    a. Framework and Tools: Four Disciplines of Execution
    b. Assignment: Start Reading Never Split the Difference, by Chris Voss
9. 3/23: Orchestrating Outcomes: Leading Change and Critical Conversations

    a. Framework and Tools: Kotter's Change Model, Skill-Will,
10. 3/30: Orchestrating Outcomes and Selling Change: The story architecture for change
11. 4/6: Orchestrating Outcomes: Mission-Based Leadership & Navigating Politics to Achieve Change
    a. Framework and Tools: Never Split the Difference, Chris Voss
12. 4/13; Revenue Operations: Go To Market Strategy, Messaging, and Execution
    a. Framework and Tools: Sinek's Start with Why, Value Based Conversation
13. 4/20: Revenue Operations: Qualification and Forecast Management
    a. Framework and Tools:
14. 4/27: Putting it all together: Threading the Frameworks into Your Framework for Success

Final Paper
– 5 frameworks that you've consumed in this class.
– How you've consumed and applied them this semester.
– How you'll apply them for impact during your life and your career (or why you won't).
– Less can be more. Thoughtfulness is the focus.

Grading

1. Class Attendance & Engagement: 50%

Class Attendance is mandatory.
This course is discussion-driven and experiential. The value is created *in the room*, not by consuming slides afterward.

How Attendance Is Taken
- Attendance is recorded via a required Microsoft Post-Class Form, shared at the end of each class.
- You are expected to - thoughtfully - complete before the end of day for that class.
- Repeated lateness of the form may impact this grade.
- The form includes reflective prompts that confirm both presence and engagement. The form conveys that you're dialed in, even if you're not talking up a lot.

Absences
- Unexcused absences will result in a grade reduction for the attendance portion of your final grade.
- Repeated absences may result in automatic failure of the attendance component (3 unexcused, max)
- Excused absences (medical, family emergency, university-approved conflicts) must be communicated in advance.

Academic Integrity: Attendance
- Submitting the attendance form without being present is considered an academic integrity violation.
- Any misrepresentation of attendance will result in:
    - Zero credit for attendance for that session
    - Potential referral under the university's academic integrity policy
    - An opportunity for you to self-assess motives

Class Engagement is Mandatory

Engagement is not measured by how often you speak, but by evidence that you are actively processing and applying the material.

Engagement may be demonstrated through:
- Thoughtful, relevant in-class contributions
- Clear evidence of reflection in post-class submissions
- Application of frameworks to your own career, decisions, or lived experiences

If you are more introverted or less comfortable speaking in class, the post-class form exists specifically to ensure you are not penalized for that. (I'm introverted too and know that introverts are thoughtful writers.)

2. Assignments and Written Submissions: 50%

This course prioritizes thinking over polish.

You will be graded primarily on:

- Thoughtfulness and Depth of reflection (see below)
- Specificity of application
- Evidence that you are integrating the frameworks into your own context

Perfect grammar or elegant prose is far less important than clear thinking.

"Thoughtfulness" defined in context of grading

Thoughtful submission demonstrates that you:

- Understood the framework or concept
- Made the learning personal, specific, and situational
- Reflected on how it applies (or does not apply) to *you*
    - *Debate and disagreement is acceptable.*
    - *Thoughtful objections are opportunities to clarify, learn, and enhance mutual learning.*

A thoughtful submission is not:

- A generic summary of class material
- A restatement of slides or readings
- Broad leadership platitudes that could apply to anyone
- Polished but impersonal writing

Grading Rubric (Applied to Papers, Reflections, and Class Summaries)

High Pass: Successful Submission

A submission earns full credit when it demonstrates:

1. Personal Application
    - Explicit references to your career stage, role, or aspirations
    - Concrete examples from your own experience
    - Clear explanation of *why* the framework matters to you

2. Specific Thinking
    - Uses course frameworks accurately
    - Applies them to a real decision, challenge, or tension
    - Acknowledges nuance, tradeoffs, or limitations

3. Evidence of Reflection
    - Shows wrestling with ideas, not just agreement
    - Connects concepts across weeks or discussions
    - Raises questions or insights that extend beyond the obvious

Partial Credit: Insufficiently Thoughtful

A submission may lose credit if it:

- Summarizes content without applying it
- Lacks concrete examples

- Feels interchangeable with another student's response

Failing Submission: Does Not Meet Course Standards
A submission will receive little or no credit if it:
- Is generic or impersonal
- Reads like an AI-generated response
- Contains no evidence of personal engagement
- Could be written by someone who did not attend class

Final Clarification (Important)
This course is not about "getting the right answer." It is about:
- Building self-awareness and a set of tools/frameworks that will propel you as a leader
- Applying frameworks to your own trajectory
- Developing judgment, not memorization

If you show me that you are thinking seriously about how this material intersects with your life, you will do very well.

Policies (including AI policy)

Participation Policy: Active participation in discussions, exercises, and peer feedback is required. There will be opportunity to provide feedback and your thoughts and CTA post class.

Attendance Policy: Attendance is expected each week. Notify instructor in advance for excused absences. The form shared at the end of each class is your attendance. **If you don't fill it out, I do not know you were there.**

Required Materials: Slides provided via eLC. Occasional pre-reads. Recommended books will often be shred. And required materials will be discussed with enough time to read within budgeted hours.

Exam/Make-Up Policy: No traditional exams. Missed graded in-class exercises require make-up within one week unless otherwise arranged.

Academic Honesty: This course follows the UGA Student Honor Code: "I will be academically honest in all of my academic work and will not tolerate academic dishonesty of others."

AI Usage Policy

You may use AI tools only in limited, transparent ways.
Permitted Uses of AI
- Grammar or spelling cleanup
- Clarifying sentence structure
- Improving readability *without changing meaning*

Prohibited Uses of AI
- Generating reflections, summaries, ideas or analysis
- Writing responses on your behalf
- As a substitute for your own thinking

Instructor Information

Professor: Russell Scherwin
Email: russell.scherwin@uga.edu
Office Hours: By appointment. Available in-person before and after class.

About Russell

Russell Scherwin is a C-level executive, a strategist, and a facilitator who has spent more than 20 years helping companies grow and helping teams & people reach their potential. His career began in an unexpected place: professional basketball scouting, which taught him how to recognize talent, elevate performance, and build teams that outperform expectations. That theme has carried through every leadership role since.

Russell has led growth for some of the most recognizable names in technology. At IBM, he served as Chief Marketing Officer for Watson Commerce, where he transformed marketing into an integrated part of revenue operations, and grew the business to ~$400M. He also led Watson Customer Engagement sales, leading IBM's largest global market to outperform while transforming the unit, building a high-performance, high integrity selling culture.

Before joining IBM, Russell spent years in product marketing, strategy consulting, and product leadership roles with firms like Sterling Commerce, Information Builders, and Arthur Andersen, giving him a uniquely cross-functional view of how companies create, position, and monetize value. He has since held executive roles in PE-backed SaaS firms, including serving as Chief Revenue Officer for FPX, where he aligned sales and marketing teams and helped drive an exit to TA Associates.

Today he runs B2B Tracks, a consulting and advisory practice where he works with founders, executive teams, and high-growth companies on sales strategy, revenue operations, and leadership development. He also speaks globally on revenue excellence, leadership, and culture. His clients include companies like Monday.com, O2X Human Performance, Figma, Gainsight, Fiserv, Underwriters Laboratories, and more.

As an educator in the MBA program at the University of Georgia, Russell teaches students how to lead, communicate, and create value in environments shaped by change. His courses focus on practical frameworks for influence, critical thinking, cross-functional execution, and career strategy. Students describe his teaching style as direct, supportive, and grounded in real-world experience. Above all, he is committed to helping future leaders develop the clarity, confidence, and capabilities to succeed from day one.

Course Meeting Information

Spring Semester 2026
Section 74509: Monday PM, 2:55-4:15pm, Correll 116
Section 74510: Monday PM, 4:35-5:65pm, Correll 116

UGA Well-being Resources

UGA Well-being Resources promote student success by cultivating a culture that supports a more active, healthy, and engaged student community.
Anyone needing assistance is encouraged to contact Student Care & Outreach (SCO) in the Division of Student Affairs at 706-542-8479 or visit sco.uga.edu. UGA provides both clinical and non-clinical options to support student well-being and mental health, any time, any place.

- Well-being Resources: well-being.uga.edu
- Student Care and Outreach: sco.uga.edu
- University Health Center: healthcenter.uga.edu
- Counseling and Psychiatric Services: caps.uga.edu or CAPS 24/7 crisis support at 706-542-2273
- Health Promotion / Fontaine Center: healthpromotion.uga.edu
- Accessibility & Testing: accessibility.uga.edu

Inclusivity Statement

The Terry College of Business is committed to promoting an inclusive learning and working environment among its students, faculty, and staff. This class welcomes the open exchange of ideas and values freedom of thought and expression and provides a professional environment that recognizes the inherent worth of every person. It aims to foster dignity, understanding, and mutual respect among all individuals in the class.